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OAKVILLE, ONTARIO / 2019 TO 2020

587 Stephens Crescent

Designed around family life

By Brett Lyver

A home shaped by everyday life, material value and the way it is built.

When I designed and built 587 Stephens Crescent in Oakville, I was putting my own funds into a home for my own family for the first time.

It brought together the responsibilities that shape my work: designing a home that feels right to live in, understanding how it will be built, and making considered decisions about where the money goes.

We expected to live there for about ten years. I wanted space to be together, room to do our own thing, and as much natural light as reasonably possible. I also wanted a clear separation between the parts of the house where we welcomed guests or clients and the spaces where family life happened.

My favourite part of the finished house is the flow. It all works.

That same attention to how things work carries through to construction. Many of my design decisions began with material costs, labour and installation in mind. I wanted each decision to earn its place through what it contributed to the home and what it took to build it.



Stone and stucco establish the home's place in its Oakville neighbourhood.

A welcoming front, with privacy built in





Left: the office beside the foyer. Right: the dining room, connected to the servery.

The office sits beside the foyer. I could meet a client without worrying about whether the kitchen was tidy.

The dining room, coat closet and powder room are also off the foyer, giving visitors access to what they need. The powder room is tucked away to give guests more privacy and comfort. The open-to-above foyer brings the grand feeling of arrival I wanted.

These decisions make it possible to welcome people into the house while keeping everyday family life private.

The rear of the house is where we come together

At the back, the kitchen, breakfast area and family room form my ideal configuration. This is where I expected us to spend most of our time together when we weren't sleeping.

The connections matter as much as the rooms themselves. You can access the kitchen directly from the mudroom, which makes bringing groceries in convenient. The servery connects the breakfast area and dining room, while the kitchen stays completely hidden from the dining room.

Guests can enjoy dinner without looking at the preparation and cleanup.

As I like to say: 'Never let them see ya sweat.'

Opening the home to its surroundings



The family room opens to its surroundings while separated windows preserve privacy.

The double-height family room, large windows and open staircase were part of my desire to open the space to its surroundings as much as possible. The room looks out onto a huge white oak tree, and I wanted the house to embrace that view.

But this was an infill lot, with four neighbouring homes in the line of sight. I chose separate windows rather than one large window to balance that openness with privacy. As an added bonus, the individual windows bring character to the room, like glass wainscoting.

Had the home backed onto conservation land or similarly private surroundings, I would have taken a different approach: glass bifold or pocket doors, with large-panel windows above, to invite as much of the outside in as possible. Here, the window design responded to the neighbours as well as the view.

Imagine walking down the stairs first thing in the morning and seeing how the sunlight catches the chandelier and scatters dancing reflections across the walls.



Morning sunlight and chandelier reflections, photographed in the finished home.

The crystals break the morning light into little flashes of colour that play across the room. As the sun moves, the patterns change, bringing the walls to life.

That's how I imagined starting the day in this home.

A little magic, every morning.

Materials chosen for the neighbourhood and the years ahead



The neighbourhood informed the exterior material choices. We knew this wouldn't be our forever home, and our plan was to sell after about ten years.

Stone and stucco felt right for that setting and that time horizon. I believe both can remain classic regardless of era when they are designed tastefully and installed well.

Every material choice also had to make sense financially. I approach a neighbourhood as having a price ceiling, and when a future sale is part of the plan, I keep that ceiling in mind throughout the design and build. A material can be beautiful and still be the wrong place to spend more money for that particular home.

For Stephens, the ten-year plan helped ground those decisions. I considered what we would enjoy while living there, how the materials suited the neighbourhood, and whether their contribution justified their cost.

The material boards offer a closer look at the finished home's exterior and interior palettes. Created from the project photographs, they help explain how the individual choices work together.

More stone, with less installation labour



I wanted more stone on the front of the house than was typical in the neighbourhood. It was a way to give the home a stronger identity while working with materials that suited its surroundings.

Using more stone meant buying more material, so I considered the installation cost alongside the purchase price. I chose a full-bed stone veneer that didn't need to be dressed. Dressing is the work of chipping the stone's face to shape it or give it a rustic texture.

Avoiding that work saved labour in both the installation and the cleanup. The lower installation cost helped offset the added cost of the extra stone.

That's a practical example of how I approach value engineering: understand the result I want, consider the material and labour together, and find an efficient way to achieve it. The knowledge of how something gets built can create room in the budget for the design itself.



The flush entry and the drain installation were considered together during design.

A flush shower begins with the framing

I framed all the showers to allow for a flush entry. I wanted that detail planned from the beginning, rather than revisited when a homeowner sees a shower curb during a framing tour and asks whether it can be removed.

I also planned for the plumber to install the drain without requiring a bulkhead in the ceiling below. The shower entry and the space needed for drainage had to be considered together.

The finished shower is what you see. The framing and plumbing coordination are what make that result possible. Thinking through both during design helps the trades carry out the intended detail.

Give the trades what they need to do good work

I also believe that making the trades' lives easier is an investment in workmanship.

The shower framing and drain planning grew directly out of a blunt question I asked the trades:

'What sucks about my drawings?'

I wanted to understand what made their work harder so I could address it in the design. Their answers informed details that affect both the finished home and the work required to build it.

If someone arrives to install part of the house and the information they need is missing, their time and attention go into trying to resolve it. They should be able to concentrate on their trade.

My responsibility as the designer is to give each trade clear, relevant information so they can understand the intended result and focus their skill on the installation. I want them thinking about how well they can execute the work, rather than cursing the designer for leaving them to figure it out.

For me, construction efficiency includes the quality of the information that reaches the people doing the building. Their time, experience and attention deserve respect.

Communication isn't delivering information, it's understanding how best it will be received.



Leave room for what makes you happy

A planned future sale gives spending decisions a particular context. A forever home brings a different set of priorities.

If this is the home you have worked your tail off to create, the things that bring you joy deserve a place in the design. If that's pink elephants, then so be it.

I want to understand what matters to you, explain what it will take to build it, and help you make those choices knowingly. Financial judgment and personal happiness both belong in that conversation.

At Stephens, the morning light catching the chandelier captures the kind of joy I wanted the home to give us.

A personal project, and a change of plans



Construction began in September 2019. Final occupancy was granted in May 2020, with all necessary inspections completed. The home was registered with Tarion and provided more than 4,200 square feet of certified living space, including the finished basement.

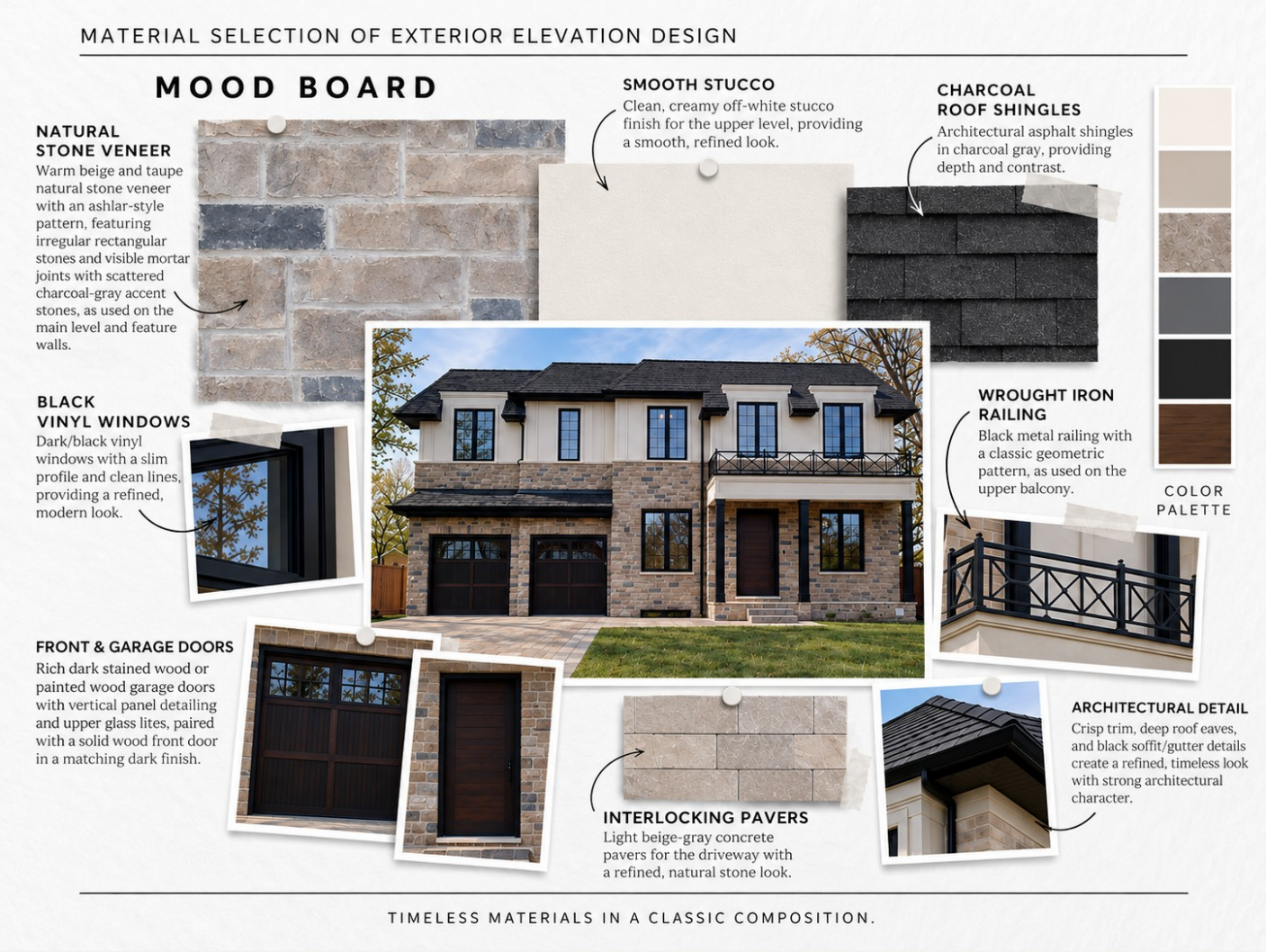
COVID changed our plans. Faced with the uncertainty of selling our existing home and carrying two mortgages, we decided to sell the new house. It sold in May 2020, approximately eight weeks after lockdown began, and the purchasers took possession in July.

We had planned for ten years there. Although that changed, the project remains a personal example of how I approach a home: understand the people and the setting, make the layout work, weigh the value of each material and detail, and think through how the trades will build it.

A home should reward the investment in it through the way it works, the quality of its construction and the pleasure of living there.

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A classic composition



Retrospective material study created from project photographs. Materials and notes confirmed by Brett Lyver.

PROJECT DETAILS

Design and construction: Brett Lyver, Accurate Designs

Location: 587 Stephens Crescent, Oakville, Ontario

Living space: 4,200+ sq ft, including the finished basement

Construction began September 2019. Final occupancy May 2020.

Texture, tone and light



White cabinetry, quartz, oak and dark wood, with colour carried through furnishings and decor.